

What is an informational interview?

The purpose of an informational interview is for you to learn more about potential careers from someone who is currently in that field by interviewing them. The goal is for you to ask questions that help you learn more about what a person in this role does on a daily basis and to make connections with professionals.

Step 1: Find a professional

The first step to conducting an informational interview is to find a professional to speak with. Consider using your current network to seek out a good connection, or you can do some research to find someone on your own. Don't be afraid to ask people you don't know! There are a lot of people who are very happy to share their experience! Consider the following ways to seek out a professional:



LinkedIn: This is a great place to find new connection! Use the search bar to find people in certain locations or with certain titles.



Ask a Bulldog: Login at askabulldog.unca.edu to connect with UNCA alumni!



Faculty and staff: You have a great network of faculty and staff at UNCA who may know a great connection for you!



Career Center: Don't forget to use the Career Center to help you! We might know some employers who'd love to connect.

Step 2: Set up a meeting

Once you've found a professional, it's time to set up a meeting! You'll need to determine a day and time that works for both of you, but also consider where and how you'll meet. Try to meet using a format where you can see each other. Avoid phone calls if possible as this can have an impact on the overall feel and effectiveness of your meeting.

Step 3: Determine your questions

In preparation for your meeting, you'll want to prepare some questions that will help you gain valuable information about the work this person is doing and what the industry is like. Before you choose your questions consider the following:



What is your goal for this meeting? There could be many reasons to conduct an informational interview (learning about a type of job, making new connections, or determining what steps you'll need to be successful). Consider what your goals are and choose questions that will help you accomplish this.



Don't just ask about the positives. You can gain some great honest feedback from informational interviews. Ask questions that will help you learn more about some of the more challenging aspects of this job or industry. This is great information to have as you consider whether or not this type of work would be a good fit for you.

Step 3 continued: Example Questions

Here are some examples of questions you might consider asking in an informational interview, but don't be afraid to develop your own list based on the information you want to know.



- 1. What does a typical work day look like?**
- 2. What is your favorite thing about your job?**
- 3. Why did you choose to pursue work in this field?**
- 4. What academic preparation is required for a job like this?**
- 5. What is your least favorite thing about this job?**
- 6. What are some common challenges that a person in this role can expect to face?**
- 7. What are the steps that someone should take to prepare for work in a position like this?**
- 8. What professional organizations are you a part of? Do they accept student members?**
- 9. What advice would you offer to someone interested in working in this field?**
- 10. Is there anyone else you recommend I connect with? May I say that you referred me?**

Step 4: Maintain the connection

Once your informational interview is finished, make sure you send a thank you note to the person you spoke with. This can be a handwritten note or an email. Here are some other pro tips for maintaining your connections:

- Add them as a connection on LinkedIn
- Start a tracking document where you can include any connections you've made, including dates of meetings and notes about what you discussed
- Follow up on any steps. If they encourage you to complete a task, do it and follow up on how it went.



Informational Interview Worksheet

▶ Getting Started

What is your goal for your informational interview? Think about: *What do you want to learn? What do you not know?*

Who can help you accomplish this goal? List a few potential folks you could reach out to. (If you want to connect with alumni, consider using Ask A Bulldog: askabulldog.unca.edu)

Example Outreach Email:

[Subject: UNC Asheville Student Introduction]

Hello Christine, Li,

My name is Evan Murthy, a sophomore at UNC Asheville. I found your name when researching UNCA alumni in the field of education and I'm really interested in learning more about your role as Vice Principal at Prichard Elementary. I am currently exploring careers within the field of education and would love to chat with you further about your experience at a day and time that is convenient for you.

Do you have some time available next week? I look forward to hearing from you.

Sincerely,

▶ Completing the Interview

What questions could you ask to help you accomplish your goal?

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2

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Informational Interview Worksheet Continued

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Finishing Up

Checklist for after your meeting:

- ☐ Send a thank you email within two days of your meeting (Remember to personalize this with something that you discussed)
- ☐ Connect with them on LinkedIn, or add them to your tracking document
- ☐ Review your goal - was it met? What are your next steps now that you have new information?
- ☐ If they give you any tasks to complete (check out an article, reach out to a contact, update your resume, etc.). Do the task and follow up on how it went! This is a great way to maintain your connection with the person.

Example Thank You Email:

[Subject: Thank You]

Dear Laura,

Thank you so much for taking the time to meet with me and discuss the field of epidemiology. Although I have researched what education is necessary to become an epidemiologist, your first-hand knowledge was invaluable to my understanding of the many career options in the field.

I have contacted a few of the organizations you shared with me in our meeting and have already heard back from one of them about opportunities to volunteer. Thank you so much for your assistance with this process! I also plan to reach out to Dr. Orzo at your recommendation by the end of this week to chat with her about her journey as well.

I appreciate you sharing your experiences with me and providing me with some great resources! I will keep you posted on how these opportunities go and would love to stay in touch as I progress in my education.

Sincerely,